

Incident Management Lifecycle — Project Documentation

A hands-on record of setting up and running an end-to-end incident management process in ServiceNow — from defining the underlying service in the CMDB through triaging, resolving, and knowledge-basing a live outage.

Part 1 — Setting Up the Service Foundation

Before any incident can be logged against a service, the underlying service structure has to exist in the CMDB. This meant creating three linked records: a Business Service, a Service Offering beneath it, and a Configuration Item representing the actual technology delivering that offering.

Step 1: Defining the Business Service

The first record created was the top-level Business Service, which represents the overall service being offered to end users.

- **Name:** Remote Access
- **Business criticality:** 2 - Somewhat critical
- **Used for:** Production
- **Operational status:** Operational
- **Service classification:** Business Service

Fields like Approval group, Support group, Change Group, Managed by, SLA, Location, and Vendor were left blank at this stage since they weren't required by the org's process yet.

Service
New record

Submit

Name : Remote Access

Model ID

Owned by

Business criticality 2 - somewhat critical

Version

Used for Production

Operational status Operational

Service classification Business Service

Comments

Approval group

Support group

Change Group

Managed by

SLA

Location

Vendor

ubmit

New Business Service record — 'Remote Access'

Step 2: Defining the Service Offering

A Service Offering was then created underneath the Business Service. Offerings represent a specific, consumable version of the parent service.

- **Name:** Corporate VPN
- **Parent:** Remote Access (from Step 1)
- **Used for:** Production
- **Operational status:** Operational
- **Business criticality:** 2 - Somewhat critical

Short Description, Description, Comments, and Contract were filled in mainly for documentation purposes before submitting the record.

< ≡ Offering
New record

Submit

Name	Corporate VPN	Approval group	
Model ID		Support group	
Owned by		Change group	
* Parent	Remote Access	Managed by	
Used for	Production	Version	
Operational status	Operational	Business criticality	2 - somewhat critical
Vendor		SLA	
		Location	

Short Description

Description

Comments

Contract

Submit

New Service Offering record — 'Corporate VPN', parented to Remote Access

Step 3: Defining the Configuration Item

Finally, a Configuration Item was created to represent the actual technical asset behind the offering — in this case, the VPN gateway.

- **Name:** VPN Gateway
- **Install Status:** Installed

Fields such as Asset tag, Assigned to, Category, and Fault count can be filled in as they become known — Fault count defaults to 0.

Click to go back, hold to see history

Submit

Name VPN Gateway

Asset tag

Assigned to

Category

Fault count 0

Installed

Install Status Installed

Submit

New Configuration Item record — 'VPN Gateway'

Note: Once all three records exist, future incidents can reference 'VPN Gateway' and 'Corporate VPN' directly through the Configuration item and Service offering fields, which gives accurate impact and routing data automatically.

Part 2 — Logging and Working an Incident

With the service structure in place, the next phase covers logging a real incident reported by an end user and moving it from New through to In Progress with correct classification, assignment, and documentation.

Step 4: Logging the New Incident

From the Service Operations Workspace, a new incident was created to capture what the caller reported.

- **Short description:** Unable to connect to Corporate VPN from home office
- **Caller:** Michael Hoefer
- **Location:** SHS Quadra 5, Bloco
- **Category:** Inquiry / Help
- **Impact:** 3 - Low
- **Urgency:** 3 - Low

Priority calculated automatically from Impact and Urgency, defaulting to 5 - Planning. Agent Assist also surfaced a relevant knowledge article ('How to configure VPN for Apple Devices') based on the short description before the record was saved and assigned a number (e.g. INC0010073).

servicenow All • Service Operations ...

Service Management INC0010071 x • Create New Inci... x +

Create New Incident

Save Assign to me

Details

Incident

Short description *
Short description: Unable to connect to Corporate VPN from f

Description

Number
INC0010073

State
New

Caller *
Michael Hoefer

Impact
3 - Low

Location
SHS quadra 5, Bloco

Urgency
3 - Low

Channel
-- None --

Priority
5 - Planning

Category
Inquiry / Help

Subcategory

Agent Assist

Q Short description: Unable ...

Article
How to configure VPN for Apple...
How to configure VPN for Apple Devices For an iPhone or iPad running iOS?...
updated 12 years ago · 2 views

Article
Automatic Replies (Out Of Office)
Automatic Replies (Out Of Office) This article explains how to use automatic replies in...
updated 4 years ago · 85 views

Article
Excel Functionality
Excel Functionality Copying formulas without changing cell locations When you want to...
updated 12 years ago · 2 views

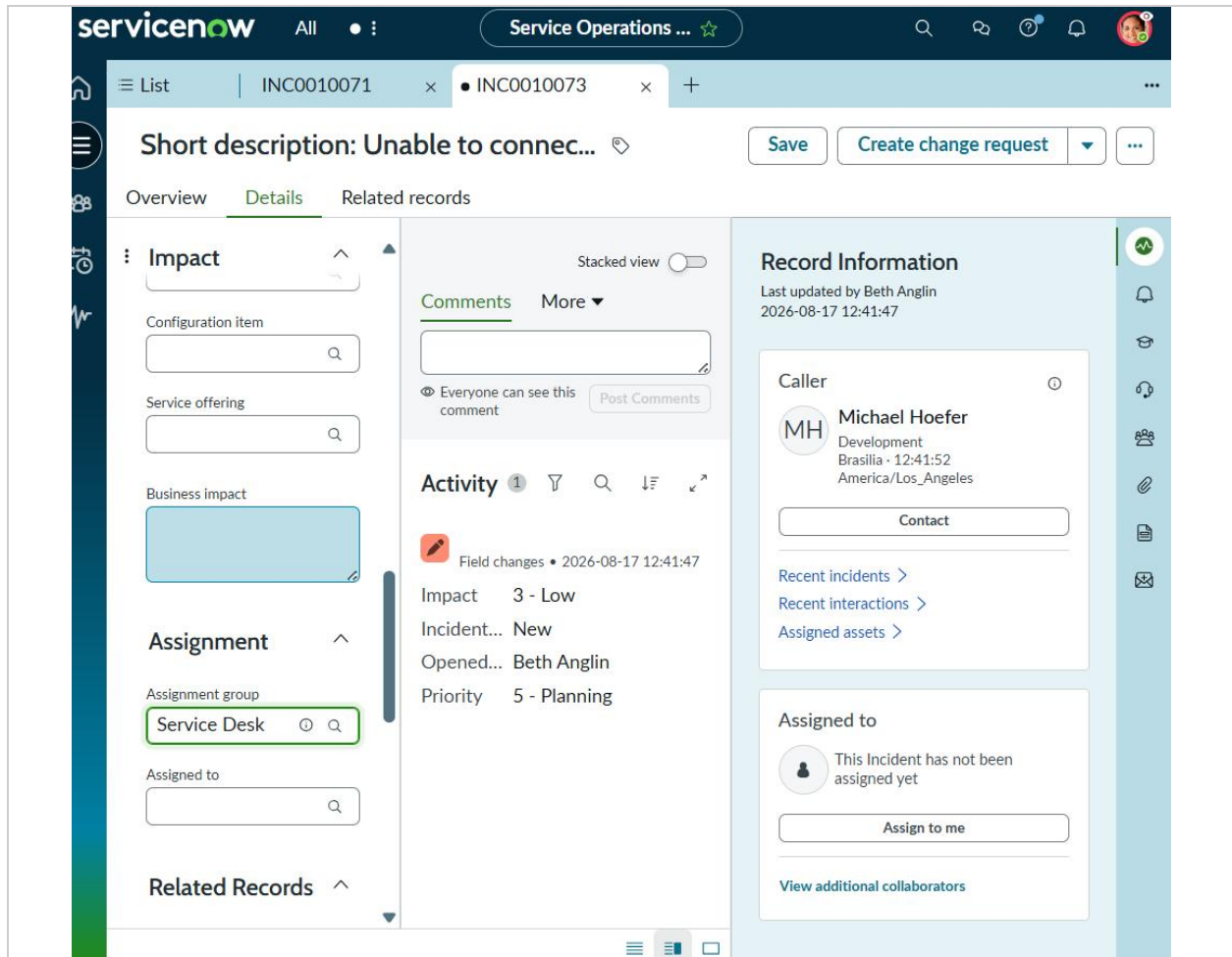
New incident form with Agent Assist suggestions on the right

Step 5: Setting the Assignment Group

The newly created incident was routed to the correct team before work could begin.

- **Assignment group:** Service Desk

At this point the ticket still showed 'Assigned to' as unset, while the caller, impact, and priority details from Step 4 remained visible in the side panels.



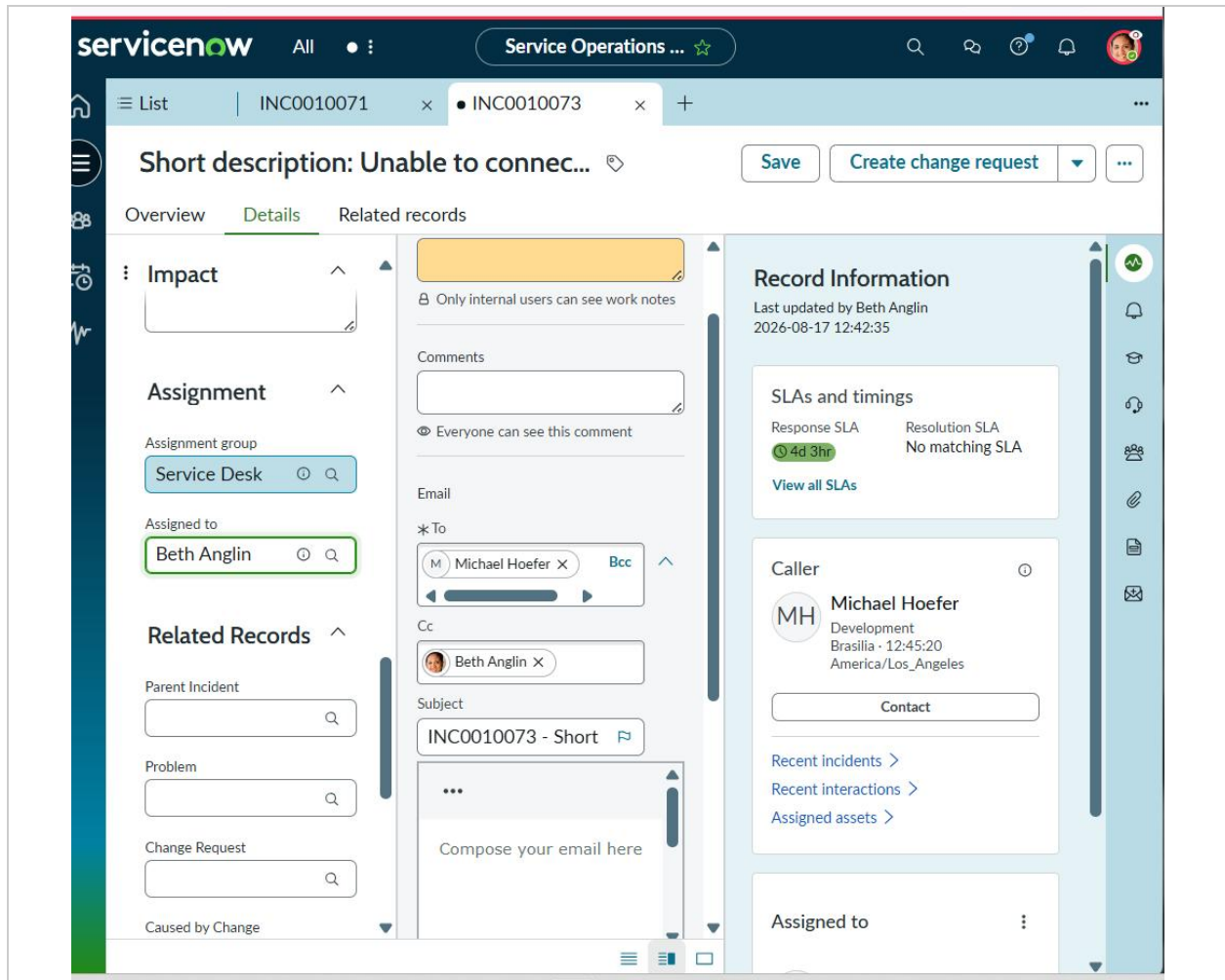
Incident routed to the Service Desk assignment group

Step 6: Assigning the Incident and Notifying the Caller

The ticket was assigned to an agent, and the built-in Email tab was used to reach out to the caller directly from the record.

- **Assigned to:** Beth Anglin
- **Email — To:** Michael Hoefer (auto-populated)
- **Email — Cc:** Beth Anglin

The subject line defaulted to the incident number and short description, and the message body was used to request more information from the caller.



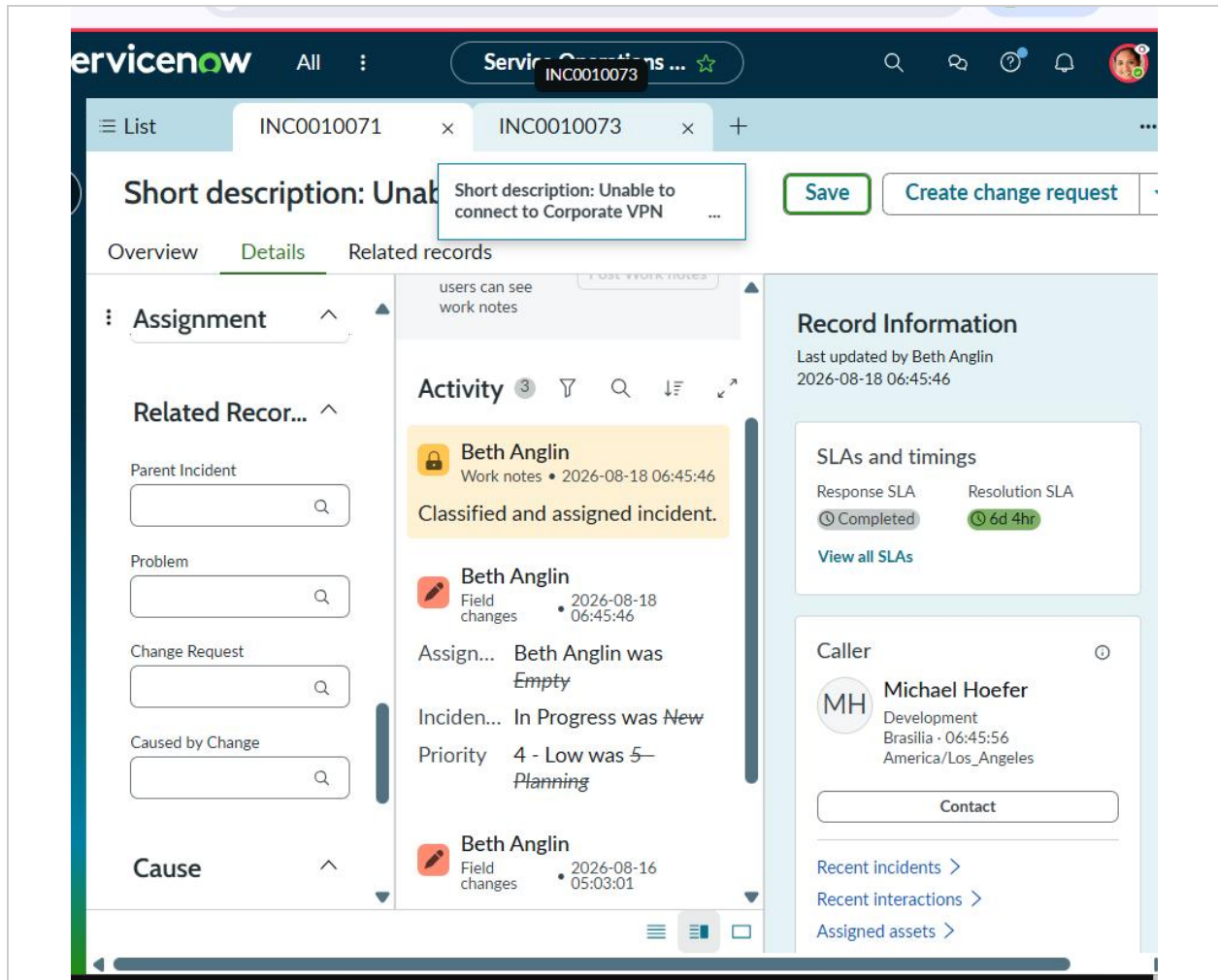
Agent assignment and outbound email to the caller

Step 7: Classifying and Updating the Incident

After reviewing the issue, the incident was reclassified, re-prioritized, and a work note was added summarizing the action taken.

- **Work note:** "Classified and assigned incident."
- **Incident state:** New → In Progress
- **Priority:** 5 - Planning → 4 - Low

Every field change — state, priority, assignment — is automatically timestamped in the Activity stream, giving a complete audit trail of who changed what and when.



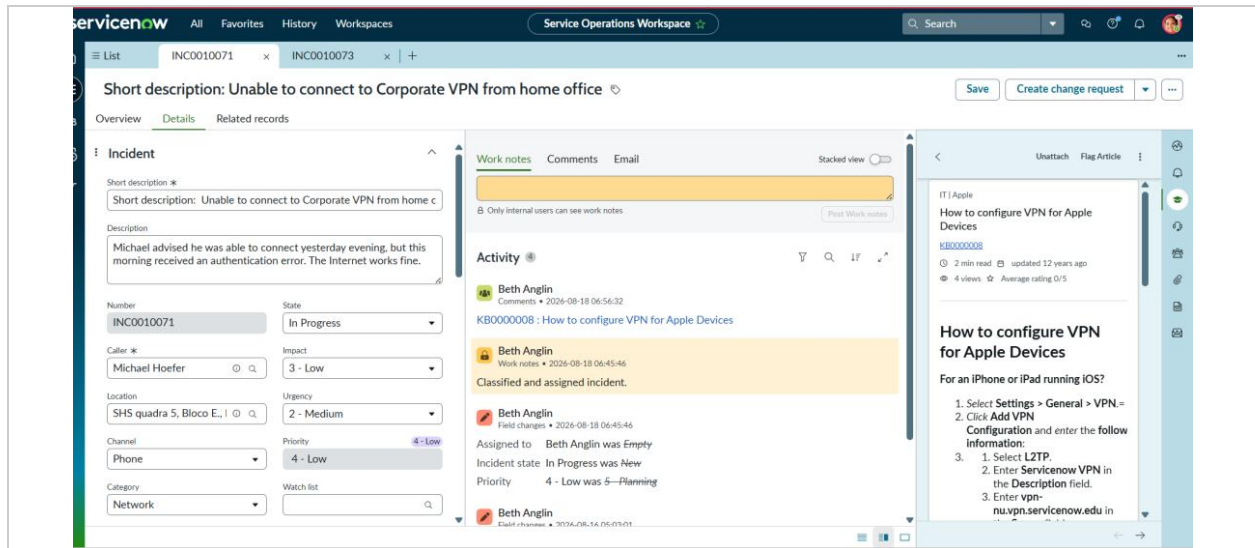
Activity feed showing the state and priority change

Step 8: Documenting Findings and Attaching Knowledge

More detail was gathered from the caller and logged, and a relevant knowledge article was attached to support the resolution.

- **Description:** "Caller confirmed the connection worked the previous evening but started failing with an authentication error this morning. General internet access is unaffected."
- **Channel:** Phone
- **Category:** Network
- **Urgency (updated):** 2 - Medium
- **Priority:** 4 - Low
- **Knowledge article attached:** KB0000008 — "How to configure VPN for Apple Devices"

The earlier work note remained visible in the Activity feed, and the linked article's configuration steps were available on the side panel to share with the caller or use directly.



Description, classification, and linked knowledge article

Part 3 — Escalating, Resolving Related Tickets, and Publishing Knowledge

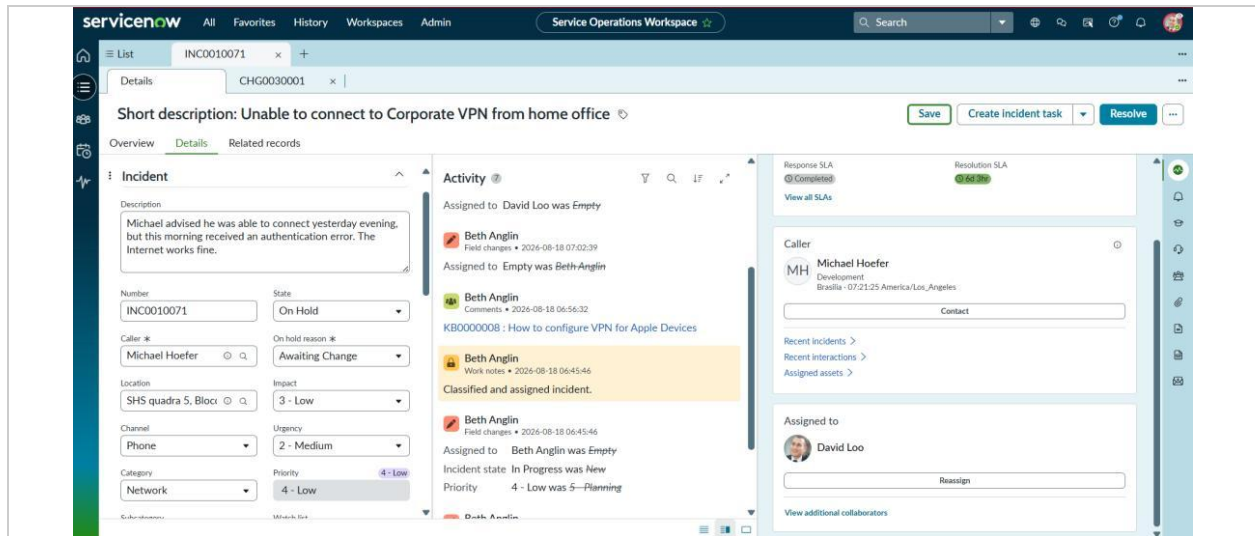
The same VPN outage generated several incidents from different callers. This part covers placing a ticket on hold pending a formal change, diagnosing and resolving the root cause, reusing that resolution across related tickets, handling a validation error, and turning the fix into a published knowledge article.

Step 9: Placing the Incident On Hold Pending a Change

Since the real fix required a formal change, the incident state was updated rather than left sitting In Progress.

- **State:** On Hold
- **On hold reason:** Awaiting Change
- **Assigned to:** Reassigned from Beth Anglin to David Loo
- **Related change request:** CHG0030001 opened and linked

The Activity feed preserved the complete history — the earlier work note, the attached knowledge article, and each field's before/after values.



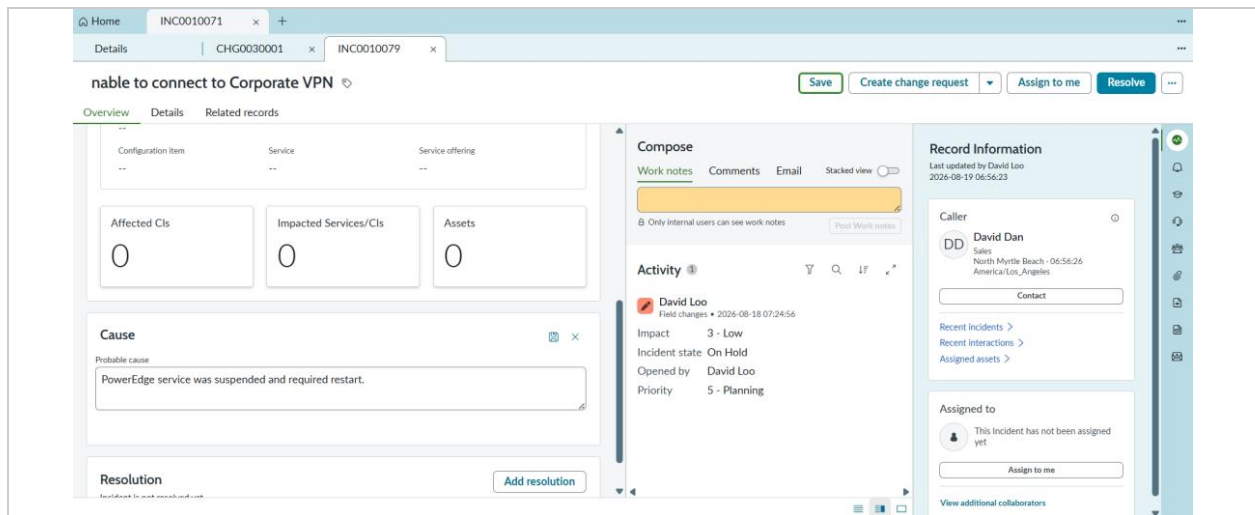
Incident placed On Hold with a linked change request

Step 10: Recording the Root Cause on a Related Incident

A second caller reported the same symptom under a new ticket. Instead of re-diagnosing from scratch, the root cause was recorded on the Cause panel so it could be reused.

- **Probable cause:** "The underlying VPN server process was suspended and needed a restart."
- **Incident state at this point:** On Hold
- **Priority:** 5 - Planning

The Cause panel can be completed independently of linking a Configuration Item — the Affected CIs, Impacted Services, and Assets counts stayed at zero until that link was made separately.



Cause panel on the related incident

Step 11: Adding the Resolution and Resolving the Incident

Once the emergency change restored service, the fix was documented in the Resolution panel and the ticket was moved to Resolved.

- **Resolution code:** Workaround provided
- **Resolution notes:** "Restarted the VPN service on the gateway as per the emergency change request."
- **Incident state:** On Hold → Resolved

The Cause and Resolution sections were visible together, and the Activity stream logged the transition alongside both newly populated fields.

Resolution panel completed and incident state moved to Resolved

Note: Resolved is not the same as Closed — once an incident is Resolved, the action buttons change to Close and Reopen, and the ticket can still be reopened if the caller reports the issue again.

Step 12: Reusing the Resolution via the Resolve Dialog

For the next incidents reporting the identical VPN issue, the guided Resolve dialog was used instead of manually editing every field.

- **Resolution code:** Workaround provided
- **Resolution notes:** "Restarted the VPN service on the gateway as per the emergency change request."

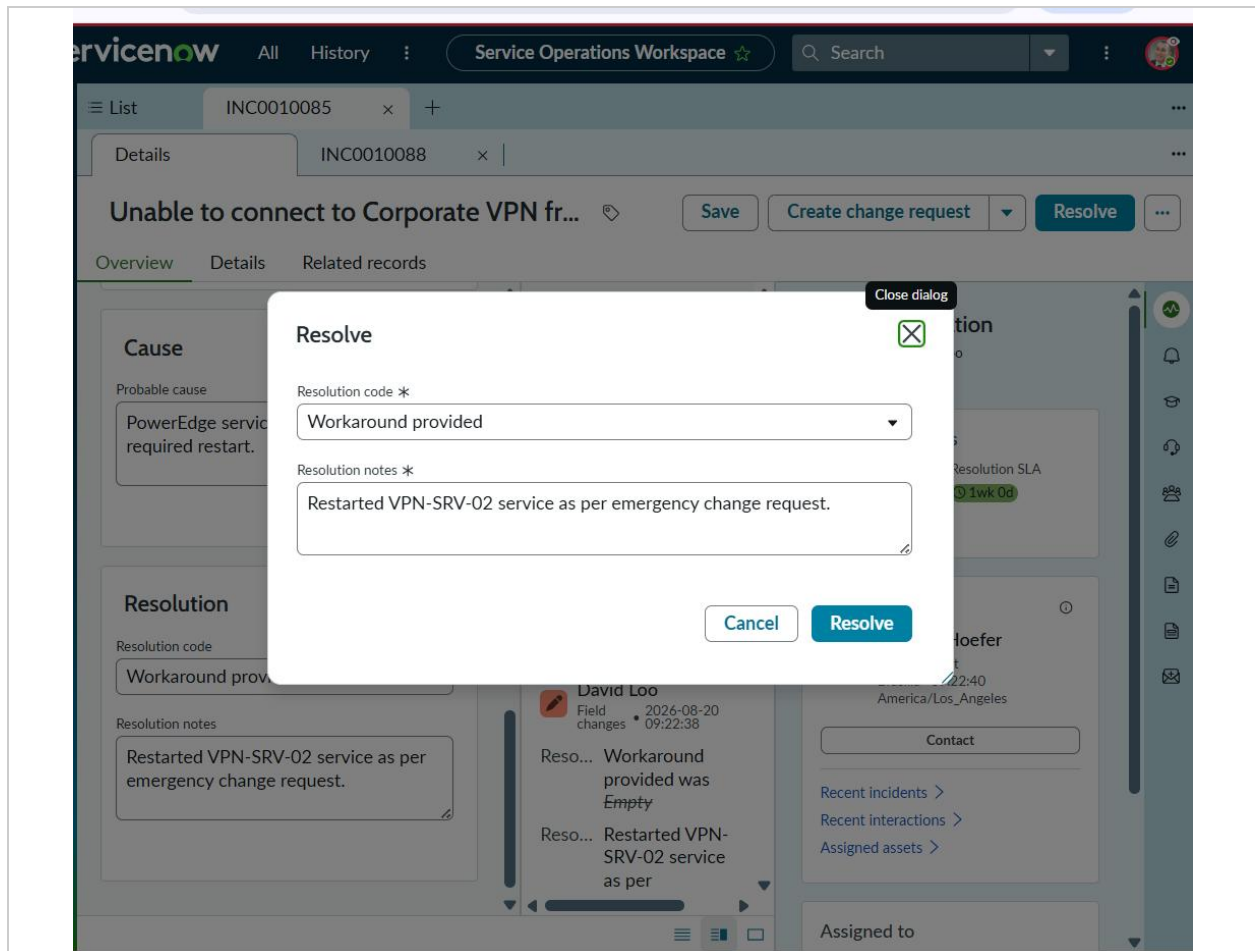
Both fields are required in the dialog. Confirming the dialog commits the values and transitions the state in one action, keeping the resolution wording consistent across every related ticket.

Resolve dialog used to reuse the same resolution wording

Step 13: Handling a Validation Error

On another related incident, an update attempt returned a system validation banner reading 'Invalid value on Update.'

- **Cause check:** Checked whatever field had just been changed — a dropdown selection, a required field left blank, or a value that conflicted with the current state
- **Fix applied:** Reopened the field, reselected a valid value, and saved again
- **Verification:** Confirmed the state moved On Hold → In Progress → Resolved, and that Resolution code/notes had actually saved despite the earlier warning



Validation error banner, checked against the Activity feed

Note: An error banner doesn't necessarily mean nothing was saved — checking the Activity feed for fields that did update, before re-entering data, avoids creating duplicate entries.

Step 14: Publishing a Knowledge Article from the Resolution

With the same fix now applied across multiple tickets, it was captured as a reusable Knowledge Article so future occurrences could be self-served without opening a new incident.

- **Knowledge base:** Knowledge
- **Workflow:** Draft

- **Short description:** Unable to connect to Corporate VPN
- **Article body — Issue:** "User receiving a VPN authentication failure error."
- **Article body — Resolution:** "Resolution notes carried over from the parent incident: restarted the VPN service on the gateway as per the emergency change request."

Agent Assist continued to surface loosely related articles for comparison while the draft was saved, ahead of being published.

Draft Knowledge Article created from the incident resolution

Step 15 & 16: Confirming Ownership and Auto-Resolving Related Tickets

Before wrapping up, the routing details on the resolved incident were double-checked for reporting accuracy, and a further related ticket was linked so it could resolve automatically from the parent.

- **Assignment group:** Network
- **Assigned to:** David Loo
- **Parent Incident / Change / Problem:** Left blank, since the ticket stood on its own rather than as a linked child record

A further caller's ticket reporting the same underlying issue was linked as a related incident and resolved automatically once the parent closed out, carrying over the same resolution code and notes without needing to be retyped.

KB0010006 v0.01

Details | INC0010098 | KB0010006 v0.01

Publish Save View Article

Details Related records

Knowledge

Knowledge base * Knowledge

Workflow Draft

Category

Short description * Unable to connect to Corporate VPN

Article body

Verdana 10pt

Issue - User receiving VPN authentication failure error.

Resolution - Resolution notes copied from Parent Incident: Restarted VPN-SRV-02 service as per emergency change request.

Agent Assist

Q Unable to connect to Corp...

Article

Eclipse configuration for Android d...

Installing the Eclipse Plugin Android offers a custom plugin for the Eclipse IDE, called Androi...

updated 4 years ago · 2 views

Confirming assignment group and ownership on the resolved incident

details | INC0010098

Unable to connect to Corporate VPN from home office

Save Create change request Close Reopen

review Details Related records

Incident

Short description * Unable to connect to Corporate VPN from home office

Description Michael advised he was able to connect yesterday evening, but this morning received an authentication error. The Internet works fine.

Number INC0010095 State Resolved

Caller * Michael Hoefer Impact 3 - Low

Location SHS quadra 5, Bloco E, Brasília Urgency 2 - Medium

Channel Phone Priority 4 - Low

Category Watch list

Activity

Work notes Comments Email Stacked view

Only internal users can see work notes Post Work notes

David Loo Field changes • 2026-08-20 09:46:51 Incident state: Resolved was On-Hold

David Loo Field changes • 2026-08-20 09:46:40 Resolution code Workaround provided was Empty Resolution notes Restarted VPN-SRV-02 service as per emergency change request, was Empty

David Loo Field changes • 2026-08-20 09:43:03 Incident state: On Hold was In-Progress

Record Information

Last updated by David Loo 2026-08-20 09:46:51

SLAs and timings

Response SLA Completed Resolution SLA Pending

View all SLAs

Caller Michael Hoefer Development Brasília - 10:17:07 America/Los_Angeles

Contact

Recent incidents > Recent interactions > Assigned assets >

Assigned to

Related child incident auto-resolved with the resolution carried over from the parent

Summary of the Full Flow

- Business Service (Remote Access) → Service Offering (Corporate VPN) → Configuration Item (VPN Gateway) were created in the CMDB.
- An incident was logged against that service on behalf of the caller, then routed to an assignment group and an agent.

- The agent classified the incident (category, urgency, priority), logged work notes, and communicated with the caller.
- Since the real fix needed a formal change, the incident was placed On Hold pending that change, then resolved once it landed.
- The root cause and resolution were documented once and reused — via the Resolve dialog and automatic linking — across every related incident reporting the same issue.
- A validation error was checked against the Activity feed rather than assumed to mean nothing had saved.
- The resolution was published as a Knowledge Article so future occurrences could be self-served or resolved faster.